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What is Diaphenomenology? A Sketch

Emmanuel Alloa

The philosophical line of inquiry opened by Edmund Husserl remains one of the most inspiring ones for contemporary thinking insofar as it places the experiential dimension at its center. Yet its initial disposition rests upon a fundamental misunderstanding. While phenomenology contests traditional representationalist accounts—which maintain that we never have things themselves, but only internal representations of them—its major advance consisted in stressing that in experience, we have things *in themselves* and not just emissaries or representatives of those things. However, this advance, which we will qualify as the “principle of selfhood” has led some to an imprudent assumption, that is that in experience, not only do we have the things themselves (principle of selfhood), but that we also have them immediately (principle of immediacy). A deconstructive analysis of experience renders such a postulation problematic: what appears (*phainestai*) is never given right off the bat, but rather appears through something else (*dia phainestai*). The paper indicates where a deconstruction of Husserl’s theoretical framework is necessary and sketches the transformations of phenomenology into a kind of thinking that makes space for the intermediaries of experiences. Diaphenomenology is based on the assumption that whatever appears appears through something. Experience must be conceived of as transphenomenality. A diaphenomenological perspective moves away from both a foundationalist account of subjectivity (where the ego is grounds for all appearances)

and a merely accusative account of it (where the ego is nothing but a pole of affections). It describes the modes in which the subject is actor, albeit not author of its experiences.

1. Phenomenology as a science of experience: The principle of selfhood

Phenomenology boasts of being the philosophy of experience. What remains to be clarified is what is meant by such a broad claim. As a matter of fact, experience can mean many different things. In everyday language, experience refers to a certain acquaintance with a certain topic or field, knowledge about something or a particular skill. Such experience is generally acquired over a long period of time and eventually becomes habit, thereby characterizing an individual as “experienced.” But individuality is not necessarily required for experience. In many cases, experience is rather transpersonal and represents what is considered common knowledge. This is the kind of experience that one generally refers to when invoking, for example, that “experience has shown...” Besides these ordinary understandings of experience, the sciences offer yet another: the concept of scientific experience has to do with principles that have been empirically observed and can be verified over and over again, thus suggesting that experience must be thought of in terms of repeatability. Opposed to such a conception is the philosophical notion of experience provided by the tradition of empiricism (Hume, Locke): experiences are equivalent to sensory impressions that act upon a receptive mind and, as such, are fundamentally unrepeatable. Kant’s notion of experience still strongly builds on such an empiricist understanding of receptivity, although he reserves the notion of experience (*Erfahrung*) to the result of working through raw impressions, which eventually become objects of knowledge.

Where does phenomenology stand with regard to all these different approaches? Is it on the side of mineness or transindividuality, repetition or unrepeatability, passivity or elaboration? At some level, all these various aspects come into play. Indeed, Husserl sounds very Kantian when he roots cognition within the strict boundaries of experience (“Natural cognition begins with experience and

remains *within* experience”¹), while he seems close to the empiricists when stressing that the “experiential data” (*Erfahrungsdaten*) are the substratum of all higher mental acts. Experience clearly starts from an individual, first-hand experience, but from an intersubjective perspective, experience also stands for the sedimented, transindividual knowledge of a community. So what is specific about the phenomenological approach to experience and does it add anything new to existing approaches?

Husserl’s position is that phenomenology leads “back to experience” (*Zurück zur Erfahrung*)²—a position which already implies that experience has been lost. If the causal hypothesis is true that all higher acts are necessarily rooted in experience, then the task is to return to the direct forms of access to the world. Instead of means of knowledge based on analogy (deduction or inference), Husserl calls for recuperating direct intuition (*Anschauung*). Unlike Kant and the empiricists, however, Husserl does not restrict intuition to sensible intuition; to intuit a geometrical figure or an intellectual category can be as direct as the evidence yielded by sense perception. According to Husserl, experience is defined by two criteria: firstly, it always refers to an *individual*, that is, to something particular, and secondly, its reference is *direct* (or as the formulation in *Experience and Judgment* goes: “Experience in the first and most pregnant sense is accordingly defined as a direct relation to the individual.”³) In other words, wherever an individual is given in direct self-evidence, he or she is given in experience.

Now how does all of this qualify for a different understanding of experience? Husserl’s phenomenology clearly diverges from those approaches that assert that we only experience that which is necessarily true. While other philosophies would draw a distinction between experience and representation on the precincts of truth and error

¹ Edmund Husserl, *Ideas Pertaining to a Pure Phenomenology and to Phenomenological Philosophy. First Book: General Introduction to a Pure Phenomenology*, trans. Fred Kersten (The Hague: Nijhoff, 1983), 5.

² Edmund Husserl, “Philosophy as Rigorous Science” [1925], in *Phenomenology and the Crisis of Philosophy*, trans. Quentin Lauer (New York: Harper & Row, 1965), 96.

³ Edmund Husserl, *Experience and Judgment: Investigations in a Genealogy of Logic*, ed. Ludwig Landgrebe, trans. James S. Churchill and Karl Ameriks (Evanston, IL: Northwestern University Press, 1973), 27.

(i.e. as a question of reference to the truth-value of what the act is about), Husserl only defines the experiential nature by virtue of its modality: when a subject appears *itself*, and not its representation, there is immediacy, and hence experience. As a matter of fact, there is no phenomenal difference between veridical and misleading appearances, which are very much alike: whether we are in deceptive or nondeceptive situations, the nature of the phenomenon is not altered. In other words, if any strong statement is to be made about the concept of experience in Husserl's phenomenology, it is that it is essentially built upon the *principle of selfhood*: experience is supposed to be direct instead of analogical; it is of something *itself*, not of something derived.

In this sense, Husserl's concept of experience is certainly not that of taking experiences to be some kind of "emissaries of the world" or to act as their "intermediaries," as Donald Davidson puts it.⁴ But on the other hand, it does not amount to a mere "openness to the layout of the world" either, as McDowell points out.⁵ By returning to experience, Husserl's primary aim is to secure solid epistemological grounds. Originary experience is to be accepted as the only basis for knowledge, or as the famous principle formulated in *Ideas* states: "every originary presentive intuition is a legitimizing source of cognition, that everything originally (so to speak, in its 'personal' actuality) offered to us in 'intuition' is to be accepted simply as what it is presented as being, but also only within the limits in which it is presented there."⁶ Not content with positing the principle of selfhood, Husserl also establishes it as the absolute precinct of phenomenology that shall not be transgressed: *only within the limits of what is intuitively given in experience*.

However, one major problem arises right away, a problem observed by many of Husserl's predecessors. Hegel aptly baptized it the "negativity of experience," that is, the fact that what the object is about always already exceeds the realm of a particular,

⁴ See the discussion in Donald Davidson, "A Coherence Theory of Truth and Knowledge," in *Truth and Interpretation: Perspectives on the Philosophy of Donald Davidson*, ed. Ernest LePore (Oxford: Basil Blackwell 1986), 307-19, here 312.

⁵ John McDowell, *Mind and World* (Cambridge, MA: Cambridge University Press, 1996), 26.

⁶ Husserl, *Ideas*, 44-45.

given experience. The *experienced* individuals do not coincide with the way in which they appear *in experience*. At the point where the immanentist perspective would run into unsolvable aporias, another structure comes into play: intentionality.

2. The structure of intentionality: Experience as meaning

“It is paradoxical,” Husserl remarks in a later manuscript, “and yet lies beyond any doubt that there is no experience in the primary straight sense of a thing-experience which, in grasping the thing at first, does not know already more than what is given to knowledge.”⁷ The experienced *object* is not exhausted by experience; in any given experience, that which is experienced exceeds its givenness. This point will be stressed by many later phenomenologists. Merleau-Ponty, for instance, formulates it as follows: “to see is always to see more than one sees.”⁸ What is perceived exceeds the sum of its appearing aspects, the sensible object is sensible by virtue of the fact that it only ever presents itself partially. On the other hand, the process through which the sensible object permanently escapes full grasp by receding into the background creates the depth that turns the experience into a sensory one. If experience is to mean more than what happens within an inner citadel and is supposed to be an embodied, practically situated experience, then any experiential act must transcend its own immanent sensory content towards something it is an experience of.

The solution that representational theories would devise would be quite simple: experiential contents are “representations” of individuals or states of affairs. Since such an option would patently contradict the principle of selfhood, Husserl takes a different direction: the “suchness” of experience is not an imperfect copy of the experienced object, it is just the way in which it is given to us. What is sensed is, for example, a string of sounds (produced by a pianist), yet what we perceive is a melody

⁷ Edmund Husserl, *Die Lebenswelt: Auslegungen der vorgegebenen Welt und ihrer Konstitution. Texte aus dem Nachlass (1916-1937)*, ed. Rochus Sowa (Dordrecht: Springer, 2008), 126 (my translation).

⁸ Maurice Merleau-Ponty, *The Visible and the Invisible*, ed. Claude Lefort, trans. Alphonso Lingis (Evanston, IL: Northwestern University Press, 1968), 247.

we recognize. Through immanent sensations we intend something else. Sensations are not representations; through them, the experienced object itself is present. However—and this distinction is crucial—while the perceived object is given *itself* (and not just a representational, secondary appearance of it), it is not necessarily given *as itself*. (A colorblind patient can only perceive a red apple as grey, and yet it is the red apple she sees and not some illusion of it.)

As a result, experiences are no more theorized as epistemological units than as *differential acts*. When something is experienced, it demarcates itself in a background, it *distinguishes itself* from something else. By virtue of this process of differentiation, the object (or state of affairs) acquires its distinctness: it is presented *as such and such*, it has some kind of “suchness”. Nevertheless, suchness should not be confused with propositionality: sensory “suchness” is rather the material for subsequent propositional assertions or judgments. Once some sort of recognizable stability is reached, objects can then subsequently become the objects of judgments: that which differs from its background will be identified *as this and that*; the string of sounds will be recognized “*as*” the well-known tune, etc.

While some phenomenologists differ on whether any “taking-as” is already an interpretive act or not (Heidegger would possibly be more inclined to this claim than Husserl), there is a consensus around the fact that it is through this contrastive, differential moment that meaning arises. If to experience is tantamount to experiencing something as something, as the other principle, that of intentionality, holds, then the emergence of something as something is equivalent to the emergence of meaning. There is no neutral, abstract way to apprehend an object other than to apprehend it in a certain light, under a certain aspect, or else for a certain purpose. Heidegger has repeatedly stressed that we do not encounter objects in their pure being; they appear already in certain respects, as practical tools, as invitations or affordances. It is by taking them in a specific way that they are experienced as meaningful. But Husserl too already described what Heidegger in *Being and Time* calls the “as-structure” (*Als-*

Struktur):⁹ Husserl is rather explicit as well when he states that “things are experienced as trees, bushes, animals, snakes, birds; specifically, as pine, linden, lilac, dog, viper, swallow, sparrow, and so on.”¹⁰

Parting with philosophical positions that surmise a kind of pure, untainted experience, such as in post-Berkeleyan idealism, Husserlian phenomenology thus defines experience not only through its principle of selfhood, but also through its relation to meaning. “Taking-as” may have many forms, from the most basic (simply gesturing to something not yet very definite by saying “look over there!”) all the way to the most elaborate assertions (“This is not a monkey, but a ring-tailed lemur”). Such a definition also has effects on our understanding of what phenomena are. Unlike the phenomena studied in natural sciences, the kind of phenomena phenomenology studies are nothing but phenomena of meaning.

When something appears, it appears as something, and this appearing *as* something is what gives the appearance its very meaning. Or to put it somewhat differently: what I see is more than an optical impression; it has a consistency of its own. That paper on the table, I see *as* a sheet of paper. However, as a result of perspectival distortion, I don’t see any square angles, I take it as a rectangular object. This process, which allows objects to come to the fore in their own right is a process that Husserl called sense-bestowing (*Sinngebung*). From an analysis of experience and its correlate of immediacy, Husserl extends the structure of sense-bestowing to all acts, whether directly experiential or not. Sense-bestowing is common not only to all intuitive acts, but also to analogical or mediated acts. The question that needs to be addressed is how this sense-bestowing comes about, which is something Husserl does in a famous passage in *Ideas*. As it will become clear, this is one crucial moment where diaphenomenology diverts from classical Husserlian phenomenology.

⁹ Martin Heidegger, *Being and Time*, trans. John Macquarrie and Edward Robinson (New York: Harper, 1962), 190.

¹⁰ Husserl, *Experience and Judgment*, 331.

3. Sense-bestowal and its origin: Husserl's double claim

In section 55 of *Ideas*, Husserl makes two essential claims: The first one is that all phenomenal unities are unities of meaning. The second one is that phenomenology is an investigation of how this meaning comes about. This first claim has hardly ever been questioned by anyone availing him- or herself of the phenomenological approach; it is the second claim, which Husserl immediately links to the first, that has stirred most of the subsequent controversies. The second claim stated in section 55 holds that the process of sense-bestowal (*Sinngebung*) is a result of a “constituting consciousness” (*sinngabendes Bewusstsein*) which “exists absolutely.”

To many later phenomenologists, this “egological” turn betrays what Husserl had discovered as the “universal apriori of correlation” (*Korrelationsapriori*)—namely, that beyond the fact that all objects are correlated to a specific mode of consciousness, consciousness is nothing without the objects of its acts of consciousness.¹¹ In the egological version, the consciousness is more than a mere “pole” of the apriori; it becomes an I in its full concreteness, which is “continuously constituting itself as existing.” A shift occurs, which moves from intuitive “evidence” as the ultimate ground of certainty to the “self-evidence” of the ego, from which all other phenomena will then be derived as modifications. By the time of the *Cartesian Meditations*, the shift from the matter of constitution towards the matter of self-constitution had already been completed and Husserl states unmistakably that as of now, “phenomenology of this *self-constitution* (*Selbstkonstitution*) coincides with phenomenology as a whole.”¹²

This egological shift has often been described, and its consequences pinpointed: if the only ego whose phenomenality displays the required evidence is my own, then all the others will merely be tantamount to modifications of my own ego, nothing more

¹¹ Edmund Husserl, *The Crisis of European Sciences and Transcendental Phenomenology*, trans. David Carr (Evanston, IL: Northwestern University Press, 1970), 166 (footnote): “The first breakthrough of this universal a priori of correlation between experienced object and manners of givenness (which occurred during work on my *Logical Investigations* around 1898) affected me so deeply that my whole subsequent life-work has been dominated by the task of systematically elaborating on this a priori of correlation.”

¹² Edmund Husserl, *Cartesian Meditations*, trans. Dorion Cairns (The Hague: Nijhoff, 1960), 68.

than *alter egos*. Paul Ricoeur has aptly summarized Husserl's shift as a slithering from a phenomenology investigating the appearances *for me* to a phenomenology investigating appearances as something drawn *from me*. Indeed, such slithering becomes conspicuous as the argumentation of the *Cartesian Meditations* proceeds:

Anything belonging to the world, any spatiotemporal being, exists for me that is to say, is accepted by me in that I experience it, perceive it, remember it, think of it somehow, judge about it, value it, desire it, or the like.¹³

Yet if everything that appears only appears insofar as it has relevance within my field of meaning, then indeed the field of appearance is an immanent field that is coextensive with the field of consciousness itself.

4. Correlationism and foundationalism

Here we find two theoretical moves. The first move can be described as Husserl's *correlationism* and it corresponds to the first part of the twofold claim in section 55 of *Ideas*. While all acts of consciousness are intentional acts insofar as they relate to something (this can be called their *aboutness*), they inversely also refer back to the instance for which this aboutness is meaningful, a subject defined here at first by nothing but a purely structural definition, as the correlative pole of a *for-menness*. Yet as Husserl continues unfolding his line of thought, the definition of the subject of consciousness shifts and we witness the second theoretical move: the *for-menness* slowly turns into a *from-menness*. This shift can already be observed in the *First Meditation*: "By my living, by my experiencing, thinking, valuing, and acting, I can enter no world other than the one that gets its sense and acceptance or status [*Sinn und Geltung*] in and

¹³ Husserl, *Cartesian Meditations*, 21.

from me, myself.”¹⁴ As if that did not make any difference, Husserl sides the immanence of meaning (*in me*) with the identification of its source (*from me*).

As the *Cartesian Meditations* continue, this second part of the claim becomes more and more central: “The Objective world, the world that exists for me [*für mich*], that always has and always will exist for me, the only world that ever can exist for me – this world, with all its Objects, I said, derives its whole sense and existential status, which it has for me, from me myself [*aus mir selbst*].”¹⁵ This and similar passages seamlessly exemplify what Ricoeur meant when he was talking about the “rather disconcerting glide from the ‘for me’ (*für mich*) into the ‘from me’ (*aus mir*).”¹⁶ What was initially nothing but a structural demand, resulting from the thesis of *correlationism* – a demand that installed the subject as an “operative I” (*fungierendes Ich*) – has now turned into a demand for causal grounding, whereby the subject has now become a “founding I” (*fundierendes Ich*).

As it has often been stressed, the “egological” turn which can be found in Husserl’s later thought is not the only strand in his texts. Some commentators stressed the existence of a parallel way, the turn to the life-world, while still some others turned to genetic analyses, whereby passivity would be given far greater importance than in the egological, Cartesian variant. Most post-Husserlian phenomenologies take their stance on this, privileging one way or the other and considering that one of the various procedures of “transcendental reduction” – the Cartesian way, the psychological way or the life-worldly way (to name only the three isolated by Iso Kern¹⁷) – must be given priority. For the purposes of this paper, I will disregard the question of how these various ways or paths relate to each other and rather focus on another aspect, which I believe has not yet been sufficiently highlighted: the fact that all of these ways, far from

¹⁴ Husserl, *Cartesian Meditations*, 21.

¹⁵ Husserl, *Cartesian Meditations*, 26.

¹⁶ Paul Ricoeur, *Husserl: An Analysis of His Phenomenology* (Evanston, IL: Northwestern University Press, 1967), 89.

¹⁷ Iso Kern, “Three Ways to the Phenomenological Reduction,” in *Husserl: Expositions and Appraisals*, ed. Frederick Elliston and Peter McCormick (Notre Dame, IN: Notre Dame University Press, 1977), 126–49.

securing an ultimate, positive ground which could be evidently intuited, epitomize the inherently mediated character of what appears.

5. World, body, sensation

This begins with the life-world, as authors such as Heidegger and Fink have convincingly argued: the life-world is never something given in itself, the world is not a thing, it does not exist in itself; rather, it is on its background that things appear, or in the words of Jan Patočka: “The world is, throughout its being, a *milieu*, in contrast to that of which it is a milieu. For that matter, the world is never an object.”¹⁸ Instead, we would be well advised to say that it is by virtue of their being in the world that things appear; the world cannot be addressed directly, except through worldly objects. It acts as a background, a horizon or a milieu of appearing.

Interestingly, the arguments put forth against the Cartesian way are quite similar. As Heidegger, Sartre or Merleau-Ponty have stressed, my subjectivity is nothing I can face in the way I could face a sensory object. The ego is adverbial rather than substantive, as Husserl already points out, when he speaks of the “mineness” (*Ichlichkeit*) of appearances. Only in exceptional moments can the *ego* be addressed directly (such as the Cartesian moment of the *ego cogitans*). Yet, as we have known well since Jaakko Hintikka, the *ego* is the result of a performative act—not an inference—and it is only consistent throughout the duration of the utterance.¹⁹ Rather than being a cause, the ego is what Husserl would call a *Leistung*, an achievement. Jan Patočka has taken this to the most radical conclusions in the kind of phenomenology he called “asubjective.” In “asubjective phenomenology,” says Patočka, “we take the subject, like everything else, to be a ‘result’.”²⁰

¹⁸ Jan Patočka, *Papiers phénoménologiques* (Grenoble: Millon, 1995), 114.

¹⁹ Jaakko Hintikka, “‘Cogito, Ergo Sum’: Inference of Performance?” [1962], in *Knowledge and the Known*, (Dordrecht: Reidel, 1974), 98–125.

²⁰ Jan Patočka, “Corps, possibilités, monde, champ d’apparition,” [1972], in *Papiers phénoménologiques* (Grenoble: Millon, 1995), 127 (my translation). See also Jan Patočka, “Husserl’s Subjectivism and the

Now of course it would be equally misleading to take the *Leistung* or achievement as a positive outcome or a resulting datum. The fact that Husserl does not want to disconnect the transcendental ego from a worldly ego and that he continuously stresses that the transcendental ego is no different from the embodied I (*Leiblich*) has been rightly taken by many Husserl readers as evidence of the necessity to regard subjectivity not from the point of view of a datum but from its operation: *Vollzug*, as Heidegger puts it; *moi opérant*, “operative I” in the words of Merleau-Ponty. Rather than being an ego that extends itself into the predicate of existence, Patočka claimed, it is the ego which appears as the appendix of the *sum*. A subject can never appear as an isolated item; a subject is the result of the very responses to affordances. The *sum* takes the form of an embodied I (*Leiblich*), which responds to “appearing affordances that open up before us” (*erscheinende Sachforderung, sich vor uns auftut*).²¹ As a result, “the *sum* is no such thing as an object, insofar as it is never autonomous, but fundamentally only ever appears in connection with and in the context of object-oriented actions.”²²

Now the subjective side of this engagement is indeed persistently present throughout all that appears. My embodied, situated perspective informs the way in which things can appear to me. It is bodily movement that produces permanent contrasts in the perceptive field, making things appear in the background of others. In that perspective, the body lets things appear as things, and thus Lévinas is right when highlighting the fact that the body “is a permanent contestation of the prerogative attributed to consciousness of ‘giving-meaning.’”²³

Call for an Asubjective Phenomenology” [1970], in *Asubjective Phenomenology: Jan Patočka’s Project in the Broader Context of his Work*, ed. Lubica Ucnik, Ivan Chvatík and Anita Williams (Nordhausen: Bautz, 2015), 17–40.

²¹ Jan Patočka, “Der Subjektivismus der Husserlschen und die Forderung einer asubjektiven Phänomenologie,” 25 (my translation).

²² Patočka, “Der Subjektivismus der Husserlschen und die Forderung einer asubjektiven Phänomenologie,” 25.

²³ Emmanuel Levinas, *Totality and Infinity*, trans. Alphonso Lingis (Pittsburgh: Duquesne University Press, 1969), 129.

However, this presence of the body is very different from the presence of the originary givenness of the sensory object. Whatever I do, I will never be able to objectify my body, cut it off from myself and place it in front of me. I do not see my body, I see in and through my body, just as I do not have anything like a self-standing I, but it is rather through my subjective situation that I have access to that which I am not. Patočka expresses this aspect as follows:

In the phenomenal field, I thus appear to myself as an inexpressible connect of means and ends, in which the appearing things and the body operating as their realizer are two inescapable and correlated moments of meaning. [...] It can thereby be said that although I am present in this causal connect and play an active part in it, I'm not objectively given.²⁴

Subjectivity thus essentially refers to what is not given, an orientation or tension to what is lacking in the field of the given. This *non-positivity of the world*, upon which a certain strand of post-Husserlian phenomenology has insisted (Fink, Merleau-Ponty, Patočka, Barbaras, etc.) and the *non-positivity of the ego*, which yet another strand emphasizes (Sartre, Levinas, Waldenfels, etc.), finds an echo in a third instance on which Husserl himself has reflected upon extensively: that of the *non-positivity of sensation*. Here again, in order to securely ground the phenomenological axiom of originary donation, the phenomenological investigation exceeds its limits. While the so-called “principle of all principles” holds that only what presents itself “originarily (so to speak in its 'personal' actuality) [...] is to be accepted simply as what it is presented as being, but also only within the limits in which it is presented there,”²⁵ then clearly sensations—or rather, what Husserl calls *hylè*—do not meet these requirements.

²⁴ Patočka, “Forderung,” 25 (my translation).

²⁵ Husserl, *Ideas*, 44.

By recapturing a conceptual pair of Aristotelian provenance (*hylē* and *morphē*, matter and form), Husserl aims at analytically dissociating two aspects in the cognitive process: “this remarkable duality and this unity of *sensuous hylē* and *intentional morphē* plays a dominant role in the whole phenomenological sphere.”²⁶ The point is that hyletic sensations do not present themselves: we do not see patches of red, but a red ball; we do not perceive acoustic vibrations, we hear a melody. As early as in the *Logical Investigations*, Husserl draws a clear division between all that can be subject to intentional consciousness, that is, all that has object-like features, and that which serves as the material or medium of such intentional aboutness. While perception would be always already intentional, its sensory “stuff” or substrate (i.e., the *hylē*) is not.

This explains, says Husserl, why we never perceive sensations, but rather perceive by the means of sensations. As Husserl writes: “Sensations [*Erlebnisse*] [...] are experienced but they do not appear as objects [...] Objects, on the other hand, appear and are perceived, but they are themselves not experienced [*erlebt*].”²⁷ It goes without saying that when Husserl talks about sensations, he fundamentally departs from the concept of sensory *data* as we know it from the empiricist tradition. The hyletic levels cannot be isolated, just as the world or the ego cannot be isolated; rather, they are transient moments in an act that, by virtue of its intentional structure, reaches beyond the immanence of the given. Following on this, Husserl gives a very precise definition of sensation as “the intuitively presentative contents of outer perception.”²⁸ The emphasis is on *presentative*, as opposed to *present*: sensation is not perceptible, it makes something perceptibly present. In that sense, it is pertinent to mention, as Jean-Luc Marion does, that sensation is not given, but giving.²⁹ Or to borrow Jan Patočka’s

²⁶ Husserl, *Ideas*, 204.

²⁷ Edmund Husserl, *Logical Investigations*, trans. J. N. Findlay, ed. Dermot Moran (London: Routledge, 2001), 1:250.

²⁸ Husserl, *Logical Investigations*, 2: §22, 235.

²⁹ Jean-Luc Marion, *Reduction and Givenness: Investigations of Husserl, Heidegger, and Phenomenology*, trans. Thomas A. Carlson (Evanston, IL: Northwestern University Press, 1998), 32.

phrase, which seems even more appropriate: sensation does not appear, it lets something else appear.³⁰

6. Diaphenomenology: Experience as transphenomenality

Let us now return to the starting point. If phenomenology claims to be a philosophy of experience and experience has to be regarded not as an empirical *datum*, but from the vantage point of meaning, this happens to have implications not only for a concept of experience, but also for a concept of meaning. Meaning is not a matter of eternal entities, mental grids, or an intellectual superstructure. *Meaning is something which appears*; it is yielded in the phenomena themselves. Conversely, says Husserl, losing phenomenal intuitivity immediately leads to a loss of meaning—that is the guiding thread throughout the *Crisis of the European Sciences*. But if one takes a closer look, the subordination of meaning to an issue of phenomenal intuitivity produces a divide within meaning: true meaning is originally intuited meaning, whereas mediated, derived meaning is meaning that is only intentionally referred to, lacking any intuition (such would be the formula of the geometrician). As Husserl puts it: the object is only “meant” (*vermeint*), it is not held in intuitive evidence (*angeschaut*).

What to do with these remarks? What Husserl says about the derived, mediated contents of consciousness comes paradoxically close to that which enables true, originary evidence. What is seen here as that which needs to be excluded from an attempt to secure true grounds for knowledge (the mediated or derived content), bears the same features as those instances we have analysed as being the operating instances that let objects appear in their own right. What bestows meaning is not meaningful in itself, it is the very lack of meaning of the hyletic moments that allow for the intentional

³⁰ Jan Patočka, *Die Bewegung der menschlichen Existenz: Phänomenologische Schriften II*, ed. Klaus Nellen (Stuttgart: Klett-Cotta, 1991), 297 (my translation).

act to traverse them and reach the meaningful content of the meant object (the patch of sensory red is insignificant, but constitutes the meaning of the perceived red ball). While Husserlian phenomenology is a permanent attempt to circumscribe a field where originary self-givenness would secure true meaning, this attempt constantly exceeds its self-imposed limits. If, for a finite being, any meaning is deemed to be only momentary and needs to be permanently reinstantiated, this can only happen through instances that are themselves insignificant. While Husserlian phenomenology sets off as an exclusion of all mediations, the very return to the things themselves forces him to take mediations into account. No appearing which is not an appearing-through, no phenomenology which is not always already contaminated by the *dia*, the medium.

What is diaphenomenology then? These remarks only sum up some results of a more in-depth analysis of the shortcomings of the phenomenological tradition,³¹ and given the format, they certainly cannot pretend to be more than just a sketch of a program. Regarding the question of subjectivity, however, while diaphenomenology follows certain readings of Husserl's egological turn, such as that made by Merleau-Ponty, Ricoeur or Patočka, some of these readings tend to throw out the baby with the bathwater. Jan Patočka pinpointed that what was initially thought of as the appearances' "pole" of address (that to which something appears, its "accusative" address) has now been turned into the agent of appearances (that *through which* something appears, its "subject"). It is probably fair to say that by moving from a purely structural description of the correlation of phenomena and the subject to whom they appear to an investigation of their transcendental conditions, the ego has shifted from being an *accusative* "to which" to a *causal* "through which." One solution would be to revert to a mere structural description, such as that suggested by Jean-Luc Marion. In such an account, the subject is nothing but an *adonné*—namely, the instance to whom a phenomenon is given, the subject as something that does not precede

³¹ Emmanuel Alloa, *Das durchscheinende Bild: Konturen einer medialen Phänomenologie* (Berlin: diaphanes, 2018). See also my *Resistance of the Sensible World*, trans. Jane Marie Todd (New York: Fordham, 2017), ch. "Toward Dia-Phenomenology", 87–103.

phenomenalization but is instituted through the very event of the phenomenon being 'given'.³² But this does no justice to Husserl's radical attempt to address the issue of the transcendental conditions of appearing.

Heidegger repeatedly stresses the point that the modern word 'phenomenon' translates something the Greeks called *phainestai*. It is noteworthy that *phainestai*, which is used in perfectly everyday contexts ("it appears that," "it seems," "that appears obvious," and so on), is always in the middle voice, the *metaxy* or "medium," a grammatical form that modern European languages have lost, located between the active and the passive. Experiencing a phenomenon is neither a matter of a private cinema inside the mind nor of a merely receptive process where the consciousness would function as a passive, sensible plate. Husserl already mentioned in his *Analyses on Passive Synthesis* that a certain disposition is needed for receptivity, a certain "turning towards" (*Hinwendung*) that makes experience something that we not only undergo,³³ but that has to be enacted by us (experience from Latin *ex-periri*, where *per* stands for a causal or medial "through"). We have to face this disconcerting finding: the ego is nothing but one of the many operations conditioning that which appears. Rather than taking the *ego* as the originary, absolute grounds that instrumentally extends its reach through ancillary mediations (writing, representations, tradition, etc.), we see the ego as but one of the instances of mediation of appearance.

A diaphenomenological perspective would thus move away from both a foundationalist account of subjectivity (where the ego is the ground for all appearances) and a merely accusative account of it (where the ego is nothing but a pole of affections). It would describe all the ways in which the subject is actor, albeit not author of her experiences. But a diaphenomenological perspective also moves past

³² Jean-Luc Marion, *Being Given: Toward a Phenomenology of Givenness*, trans. Jeffrey L. Kosky (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2002). A similar proposal has been made by Claude Romano, who speaks of the subject as *advenant*, i.e., as that *to which* something happens and which comes about through this event. See Claude Romano, *Event and World* (New York: Fordham, 2009).

³³ Edmund Husserl, *Analyses Concerning Passive and Active Syntheses*, trans. Anthony J. Steinbock (Dordrecht: Kluwer, 2001).

questions solely related to the issue of subjectivity in order to address the role of all media of appearing. Husserl might be right when asked to return to the things themselves (principle of selfhood), but the fact that it is the things themselves that are experienced, and not their representations, does not mean that the things are experienced *directly*.

Perception itself is permanently mediated: we look through glasses, lenses, mirrors, air or water; we look through technical media or media of nature. While every vision is thus always already tele-vision, a seeing-through means that disregards that through which we see. As a matter of fact, most of the things we have in mind come to us by roundabout means so to speak. The discovery of the mediated structure of perceptual experience would have to be generalized to the sensible world as a whole. We do not perceive sensations; it is through them that we perceive; we do not perceive aspects; it is through their intervention that we grasp the thing. We never possess ourselves entirely; it is through the elements, which we will never be able to completely elucidate, that we have access to ourselves. Just as we did not witness our own birth, we cannot return to ourselves without others who serve as witnesses to that which escapes our immediate grasp. Our present situation gives itself through the mediation of memories, both personal and intersubjective, and against the ground of a future into which we project ourselves individually and collectively.

The same goes for our finitude, which Heidegger wanted to make into a new “originary.” But our own death always comes second; it is other people’s deaths that we encounter first. The same is true regarding the encounter with the Other, which a certain ethical philosophy would like to isolate from any social context. There is no immediacy of the encounter; the encounter with the Other is already mediated by the relationship with third parties. The same goes for the norms that govern behaviors: a norm is never directly in front of us—it is not a thing; it is through it that social relations are organized, and it is only through these relations that the coherence of the norm shines through. The institution of something unheard of or unprecedented (a scientific discovery, an artistic creation, a historical revolution) and its profoundly

innovative character are perceptible only through the previous state, which one moved through unconsciously and which suddenly appears in broad daylight as past, obsolete, outmoded. However disruptive the event may be, it is rooted in a specific configuration that makes it emerge. Every creation, however radical, remains a matter of mediation, inasmuch as it discovers, in what is there, the means to go forward toward something that no one had been able to see before because it appeared meaningless.

Merleau-Ponty has formulated this succinctly: “There is no vision without the screen: the ideas we are speaking of would not be better known to us if we had no body and no sensibility; it is then that they would be inaccessible to us.”³⁴ The material media of appearing are not what sullies its meaning; they are its precondition. As meaningless, insignificant devices, it is through these media that significance emerges. Heidegger was right when criticizing Husserl’s excessive focusing on the binary pair of *intentio* and *intentum*. When very early on, he called for a broader account of what he called “Sinnführungen,” or guidances of sense, he aptly underlined that beyond the “content-sense” (*Gehaltssinn*) and the “referential sense” (*Bezugssinn*) there is also an “enacting sense” (*Vollzugssinn*)³⁵ which alas has remained underestimated in phenomenology to this day. The “enaction” or “performance” of what is should be addressed in a broader sense, beyond issues of transcendental subjectivity. Hence the proposal to start with describing the media of appearances. Whenever something occurs to us, it occurs through media and it is instantiated on their behalf. Insofar as media impinge on what they instantiate, any sense-bestowal (*Sinngebung*) implies “displacements of meaning” (*Sinnverschiebungen*). Every recapturing of meaning always defers its final grasp, and in this respect, every *iteration* is an *alteration*, as suggested by the root of the word (*iter*, ‘again,’ is related to the Sanskrit word *itara*, इतर, ‘other’). In the wake of Merleau-Ponty’s and, even more so, Derrida’s reading of

³⁴ Merleau-Ponty, *The Visible and the Invisible*, 150.

³⁵ Martin Heidegger, *Die Grundprobleme der Phänomenologie (1919/1920)*, ed. Hans-Helmuth Gander (Frankfurt am Main: Klostermann, 1993), 261.

Husserl,³⁶ we would like to suggest a reshaping of phenomenology towards medial or dia-phenomenology. While phenomenology has done a great deal to show that it is possible to recapture things as they present themselves (principle of selfhood), this does not necessarily mean that they present themselves directly. Whatever appears: it appears through something else; phenomenality is transphenomenality.

³⁶ See my "Writing, Embodiment, Deferral: Merleau-Ponty and Derrida on 'The Origin of Geometry,'" *Philosophy Today* 58, no. 2 (2014): 219–39.